that it was practical to persist with nonalignment. This posture was vindicated when the United States publicly criticised China's use of force against an Indian police post in August 1959, and the Soviet Union not only "declined to take sides" but privately urged China to settle the dispute peacefully.[59] More generally, the United States began to see India as a democratic counterexample that must be economically strengthened against Communist China.[60] For its part, the Soviet Union began to supply arms to India, including high-altitude transports, helicopters, and eventually MiG-21 fighters driven by the imperative of building India up as "a balancing force" and a "future bulwark" against China in Asia.[61] Given this correlation of forces, Nehru believed that until an open split occurred within the Communist camp, the Soviet Union would restrain China from initiating war against India.[62]

To sum up, the calculation that the threat from China was limited to border incursions, that it would be restrained by the international correlation of forces from initiating war, and that a cooperative understanding could be forged with that country led India to underbalance or inefficiently balance against China until the 1962 war. That is, while India consolidated state presence in and control over the border regions, integrated the Himalayan states into its security architecture, deployed troops and crafted defence plans, and manoeuvred to gain diplomatic support from the superpowers, these proved insufficient to ultimately deter China from initiating hostilities or prevent defeat in war.

Internal and external balancing after the 1962 war